us hugged each other after the announcements. It was a coincidence that all three pupils of Babs Sir—Supreet, Anuradha and I—were among the top three. He was so happy and proud that night. I could only imagine how happy my parents would be the next day, when the reviewing officer would present the trophy to me during the parade.

It was 29 June 1996. Papaji, Maa, Dada and my friend from eleventh standard, Shivani, had come to watch the parade the next day. Papaji, who was dressed in his uniform, was told by the ushers, junior-term cadets, that their seats were reserved in the first row. Since only the parents of the trophy winners were made to sit in the first row, Papaji now had a hint of what was in store. The POP started and while marching past the reviewing officer of the parade, I stole a glance at my family. They were happy as they looked upon their marching daughter. Then came the most awaited moment. The reviewing officer started putting wings on the passing-out cadets' uniforms. These wings are considered sacred—there's a different sanctity to them. There is a saying, 'Not all the gold in the world can get you these wings, but once you have earned them, nothing in the world can take them away.' Only those who have been through flying training in the armed forces know how true this saying is. High tea was organized for the cadets and their parents after the POP. I ran straight to Papaji and saluted him—as an officer saluting another. He saluted back. It was the proudest moment of my life.

Maa was so happy she almost cried when she hugged me. 'How did such a lazy person as you manage to get this trophy?' joked Dada and hugged me. I made my parents meet Assey Sir and his wife. He even clicked our family photograph and then joined us for one. I cherish these two photographs even today. Anuradha brought her mother to meet my parents.

'So, this is it then?' she said to me while my parents were busy chatting with Anuradha's mother.

'I guess,' I said, mixed emotions taking over. 'I wish we were posted together.' Our postings had been given to us a week prior to the POP.

'I'll miss you in Bareilly,' Anuradha said with moist eyes.